

A GUIDE FROM THE CONSCIOUS CREATOR

The Relationship- Driven Advisor Starter Guide

How to build trusted relationships with the people behind a destination, and turn them into trips your clients ask for.

HOSTED BY NICCI GROTEFENDT · TRAVEL GHR

Know the people. Know the place.

Relationship-driven travel is built through first-hand relationships with local people. It is the difference between recommending a place and standing inside it.

Relationship-driven means we know the person driving the van that picks up your client, and the real owner of the villa where your guest sleeps.

This guide is a practical starting point. It is organized around seven habits you can begin this month, with a suggested pace at the end. You do not need a lot of time or travel to start. You need curiosity, a notebook, and a willingness to ask good questions.

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1. Arrive as a curious guest

The best conversations begin before you ask for anything. Spend time. Eat where the people who live there eat. Ask what they would show a visiting friend.

A single small discovery can change how you see a place. On one trip to Playa del Carmen, a friend who lives there walked Nicci through a local grocery store and explained why the baggers work for free: senior citizens who volunteer so that shoppers' tips become their income, a quiet program that keeps elders engaged and supported. That kind of knowledge comes from time spent on the ground, with the people who live there.

2. Learn whose hands hold the experience

Every experience you sell has people behind it. Make a list for one destination:

- The driver who meets your client
- The owner or caretaker of the place they will stay
- The chef, the host, or the guide who shapes the day
- The community member who can explain why things are done the way they are

Learn their names, how they came to this work, and what they are proud of. Write it down, and ask before you share any of it.

3. Ten questions worth asking a local partner

Use these in your first real conversation. Listen more than you talk.

1. What do you most want a guest to understand before they arrive?
2. What does a great day with you look like, from the guest's side and from yours?
3. How do you work with people in your community, and how can guests support them?
4. What should a guest bring, wear, or know in advance?
5. How much notice do you need, and what makes planning easier for your team?
6. What are your terms for deposits, changes, and cancellations, in writing?
7. What happens if the weather or the plan changes?
8. Who else in your community do you trust and recommend?
9. What would you like advisors to say about you, and what should they leave unsaid?
10. What is a story from your work that guests rarely hear?

Try this

Pick three questions and bring them to your next call with a partner. Write down the answers in their own words.

4. See it for yourself

Whenever you can, visit. Stand inside the villa. Sit in the kitchen. Ride the route your client will ride. First-hand knowledge shows up in every recommendation you make.

As you vet a partner, a short checklist helps:

- ☐ Meet the owner or the person who runs the place day to day.
 - ☐ Ask about licensing and insurance where they apply.
 - ☐ Get terms in writing, including cancellations and changes.
 - ☐ Ask for names of other advisors or guests you may speak with.
 - ☐ Note how the team treats each other, not only how they treat you.
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5. Keep the story, with permission

Carry a notebook or use voice memos. Capture what you saw, who you met, and what they said, in their words.

- Ask before you photograph or name anyone.
- Confirm facts with your host before you publish them.
- Credit the people and places that made the moment possible.

6. Notice where the money lands

A relationship-driven itinerary protects the destination and channels tourism dollars into local hands. As you plan, ask each partner how their work supports their community, and let that shape what you recommend.

7. Turn a relationship into an offer

When a client asks about a place you know, you have something specific to give them. Describe it plainly:

- **The people:** who they will meet, by name where permitted.
- **The place:** what makes it worth the journey, in your own words.
- **The care:** what you will arrange and who you have already spoken to.
- **One invitation:** a single, clear next step for the client.

Your clients are choosing you. Say what you provide, and let your first-hand detail do the work.

A suggested first 90 days

MONTH	FOCUS
One	Choose one destination you know. List five people behind it. Write the ten questions you will ask.
Two	Hold three real conversations. Take notes in their words. Confirm facts and permissions.
Three	Publish your first story, with permission. Offer one trip you can describe from first-hand detail.

Build this alongside other advisors.

The Conscious Creator is a five day advisor immersion in Akumal and Tulum, February 8 to 12, 2027, hosted by Nicci Grotefendt of Travel GHR in partnership with Living Dreams Mexico, a locally owned and staffed partner.

The program provides first-hand experience, practical education in storytelling and publishing, and relationships with local people. Fifty travel advisors are selected by application, and every application is read personally.

See if it is a fit.

Read a look inside the five days and the application at consciouscreator.app.

The ideas in this guide are practical suggestions for building relationships and telling accurate stories. They are not legal or business advice, and your own agreements and local rules always come first.